

TREATMENT OF SLAVES.

The New Orleans *Bulletin* directs attention to what it regards as an excellent move which has been made in the Mississippi Legislature now in session—a bill effectually to prevent the abuse of slaves. It says:

The motive which prompted the introduction of the bill was, enlightened and liberal humanity.—To show this we quote a paragraph from the *Missippian*:

Gen. Starke, in offering his resolution, well remarked that the only true friends of African slaves, are the people of the Southern States. They furnish them good homes in a climate peculiarly adapted to them. They protect them and make them a part of their household. They discipline them as they do their children. This is the course, he remarked, generally pursued by masters and managers; but there are occasionally to be found monsters who in their treatment of negroes, violate the laws of humanity, and the object of Senators in adopting the code should be to fix on our statute books some remedy that will reach and bring them to punishment. Humanity requires it, public policy demands it, christianity appeals in its behalf.

As our black code will, we suppose, undergo revision by the Legislature, we trust some provision similar to the *Mississippi* bill will be made, whereby monsters who disgrace their species, who are found every where, East, West, North and South, and in every relation of life, may be properly dealt with.—In order that our readers may understand the nature of the amendments offered by Mr. Starke, and which passed the Senate by a vote of 14 to 9, we append them. They are the following:

1st. That whenever any person shall be charged under oath, by any citizens of the State, before any justice of the peace, with having violated any of the provisions of this act, it shall be the duty of such justice immediately to issue his warrant commanding any constable or other officer of his court, to bring before said justice, the slave or slaves upon whom it is alleged such crime (cruel and unusual punishment) has been committed; and it shall further be the duty of such justice to appoint three or more respectable slaveholders to examine the person or persons of such slave or slaves, to ascertain if the proof of the infliction of such punishment exists or not, on his or her body.

2d. In all cases where it is established that such punishment has been inflicted, the person or persons having the immediate control of such slave at the time of its infliction, shall, until the contrary is proved, be presumed to have inflicted the same.

3. In all trials for offenses under this act, it shall be lawful for either party to prove the general character of the accused for cruelty or humanity to the slaves under his or her control.

The *Mississippi* continues:

Heretofore, whilst we had laws to punish those who maltreated slaves, there was no provision for an examination of the slave as provided in the first of these articles, and in fact there are new and stringent provisions throughout the amendment.

This bill, with its amendments, contemplates ample protection to the slave. It requires he should be well fed, clothed and cared for, and in no way cruelly and inhumanly treated.

Another important amendment (offered by Mr. Ellett,) touches the sale of slaves, and embodies the Louisiana provision relative to hereditary vices, defects and maladies. This gives greater security to the purchaser, and will make those who buy to sell again more cautious in their selection.

Another very important amendment (offered by Mr. Greer) consists of four additional articles taxing free negroes between the ages of 18 and 50 years, \$5 each annually, to raise a fund for their transportation to Liberia, etc., the State also appropriating from its treasury an amount equal to the tax so raised to be a part of said fund. This amendment was adopted with but little debate, and by a very decided vote. It is similar to the Virginia laws on the same subject, and founded on them I understand. The bill passed the Senate with 33 amendments.

We are especially in favor of the clause imposing a tax of five dollars upon every free negro annually, by which a fund is to be raised to transport free persons of color to Liberia, and to which fund the State is to contribute an equal amount. We trust similar provisions for this purpose will be made by our Legislature at the present session. A large sum would thus be realized by which our free colored population could be, and doubtless would be, annually diminished, and the Christian colony which has for years been growing into existence and importance on the outskirts of heathen Africa, in the same ratio augmented; and thus two objects of great importance would thereby be promoted.

The colony of Liberia on the Western shore of Africa presents one of the sublimest moral phenomena of the present age. Ridiculed and sneered at at first by many, and bitterly reviled as it ever has been and still continues to be to this day by the abolitionists, nevertheless the little colony has been steadily progressing in numbers, in intelligence, in the power of its people to govern themselves, and to subdue the wilderness with the savages who inhabit it on their borders. Africa is the natural and only home of the free black man, and to it he ought to return as fast as he can obtain the facilities for so doing.

We are no prophets, and we may be mistaken; but if Providence does not design the regeneration and consequent civilization and exaltation of that most degraded and besotted of all the grand divisions of the world through the expanding nucleus of Christianized and manumitted slaves upon its Western coast, then all the indications of the times are to us profound and impenetrable mysteries. Thus much in connection with this subject we could not refrain from saying.